to the hilt. A small group of extremists among them started retaliating, and Maulana Haq Nawaz Jhangvi, a young Sunni cleric of Jamia Mosque, Pipplian, Jhang, Punjab, formed Anjuman Sipah-e-Sahaba (ASS) later renamed Sipah-e-Sahaba Pakistan (SSP) to counter the Shi'a surge.[3] In February 1990, Haq Nawaz Jhangvi was allegedly gunned down by his Shi'a rivals (*The News International*, 2009). SSP can be termed the pioneer of sectarian extremism and sectarian militancy in Pakistan. It resorted to killings of rival Shi'a in Punjab and Karachi.

SSP was proscribed on 15 January 2002. It renamed itself Millat-e-Islamia Pakistan (MIP). Meanwhile, its firebrand leader Maulana Azam Tariq, who was elected Member of the National Assembly (MNA) in the general elections of 2002, was gunned down on 7 October 2003 in Islamabad.

A few months before his death, Maulana Azam Tariq seemed to have become comparatively moderate and more inclined towards adopting constitutional approach to run its party. According to him, Lashkar-e-Jhangvi came into being because he had decided to step back from a violent approach. The hardliner elements detested this softening of his stance and formed LeJ to continue its violent activities.[4] Later, SSP renamed itself *Ahle Sunnat wal jamaat* (ASWJ) headed by Maulana Ahmed Ludhianvi, who was more moderate in approach and political disposition than the late Maulana Azam Tariq.[5]

LASHKAR-E-JHANGVI (LeJ)

LeJ was established in 1996 as a Sunni sectarian group in Jhang district in the Punjab province of Pakistan. It is an ultra-militant splinter group of Sipah-e-Sahaba Pakistan (SSP). SSP was formed in the late 1980s by Sunni extremists, most notably Haq Nawaz Jhangvi in response to the perceived 'growing influence of Shi'a and Iranian government'. Those who split from SSP gave the reason that the organisation no more has the ideals of its founder Haq Nawaz Jhangvi after he was killed by his rival sectarian extremists in February 1990. After his death, some of its leaders, including the then central secretary for information of SSP, Riaz Basra, started leaving the organisation to continue their violent means of eliminating the Shi'a from Pakistan. They believed that SSP was turning into a political platform only and had deviated from its original purpose. Initially, these people formed different organisations out of it, namely